

Analytical Essay

By Md. Miraz Hossain (233012010)

Algorithmic Content Distribution as Political Artifact

MSJ2101: Communication and Technology
Department of Media Studies and Journalism, ULAB
Summer 2024

Introduction

In 1980, Langdon Winner asked whether artefacts have politics. His answer came from Robert Moses's bridges on Long Island — built low, deliberately, so that buses carrying Black and poor New Yorkers could not pass underneath and reach Jones Beach. The politics were in the concrete. Not in how the bridges were used, not in the intentions of drivers, but in the physical design itself (Winner, 1980). It was a provocative claim then. It is an obvious one now — obvious because we live inside a far more consequential version of the same problem.

The artefact in question is no longer a bridge. It is an algorithm. Specifically, the content distribution systems that decide what billions of people see when they open Facebook, scroll TikTok, or search for news on Google. These systems are not neutral pipes. They make choices — about what is visible and what is buried, whose speech gets reach and whose does not, what counts as credible and what gets flagged as suspicious. Those choices are inscribed in technical design. Their consequences are political.

This essay draws on Winner (1980), Tarleton Gillespie's (2014) account of platform politics, and José van Dijck's (2013) analysis of connective media to examine three registers in which algorithmic politics operate: the structural encoding of values in system design, the governance of visibility as a form of power, and the production of epistemic hierarchies that cut unevenly across the Global South. The Bangladesh context runs as a thread throughout — not as a special case but as an unusually clear illustration of dynamics that operate globally.

I. Technical Artefacts and Political Inscription

Winner's argument distinguishes two ways a technical artefact can be political. The first is deliberate: a system designed to produce a specific social outcome, as Moses's bridges were designed to exclude. The second is structural: political

consequences that follow from design choices made for other reasons entirely — the choice of materials, assumptions about who the user is, the institutional interests that funded the project. In both cases, the politics are in the thing itself (Winner, 1980, p. 123).

Facebook's early News Feed algorithm fits the first mode. Internal communications, later made public, show it was designed to maximise time-on-platform by surfacing content that provoked emotional response — outrage, fear, moral indignation (Haugen, 2021; Bail et al., 2018). That was a deliberate choice. The engineers knew what they were optimising for. The choice to prioritise emotionally activating content over accurate, corrective, or deliberative content was made in service of an advertising model. Its consequences were epistemic and political, not incidental side effects.

The structural mode is what Gillespie (2014) calls the “politics of platforms.” Every platform must decide what content to allow, remove, recommend, and downrank. Those decisions require a definition of credibility, a theory of harm, a standard of “good” and “bad” content. None of these are self-evident. They are culturally specific, institutionally shaped, and contested. When a platform defines “authoritative news sources” as outlets with established verification infrastructure, it encodes a theory of journalistic credibility that systematically favours large Western legacy media over regional outlets, community journalism, and news organisations from the Global South. The definition runs as a ranking signal in the algorithm. It is technical. It is not neutral (Gillespie, 2014, pp. 167–194).

Van Dijck's (2013) concept of the “culture of connectivity” adds a third layer. Platforms do not merely mediate existing social connections. They actively produce new norms of what connection means, new metrics of what speech is worth, new hierarchies of visibility. The “like” button is not simply a technical affordance for expressing approval. It encodes a particular theory of social value — quantifiable, public, aggregable — and over time it shapes what kinds of speech are produced, in what register, for whom. The political inscription accumulates. It is not in any single design decision but

in the cumulative logic of a system that consistently rewards certain kinds of expression and consistently penalises others (van Dijck, 2013, p. 13).

II. Visibility as Power: The Governance of Reach

The most immediate politics of algorithmic distribution is the politics of visibility. To appear in a user's feed is to exist in their information environment. To be downranked or filtered is to be practically invisible, regardless of whether the content remains technically accessible. This is not entirely without precedent — editorial gatekeeping has always determined which stories reach which audiences. But there is a structural difference. Editorial decisions were made by identifiable institutions operating under professional norms that were, in principle, contestable: a journalist could challenge an editorial judgement, a civil society organisation could pressure a broadcaster, a regulator could investigate a pattern of coverage. Algorithmic gatekeeping operates through proprietary criteria that are continuously updated and not subject to public accountability in any comparable sense. The power is real in both cases. Its legibility — and therefore its contestability — is not (Gillespie, 2014).

For journalism this has a concrete consequence. An editor deciding what goes on the front page applies a professional judgement about public importance, however imperfect. An algorithm deciding what appears in a user's feed optimises for predicted engagement. A story about political corruption that is carefully sourced and publicly significant may reach fewer people than a story that is emotionally activating and shareable — not because readers are indifferent to corruption but because the system does not reward accuracy, it rewards engagement. Those are different objectives, and the difference is not incidental to the algorithm's design. It is produced by it.

I reported on the Azimpur incident in August 2024 for The Business Standard — a photograph of a woman tied to a tree, misidentified and circulated across South Asian platforms as evidence of communal violence against a school principal. The false narrative spread faster than any correction the local fact-checking infrastructure could

mount. Not because users preferred the false version. Because the emotional architecture of the platform rewarded the content that provoked the stronger response. The algorithm did not fabricate the misinformation. But it governed who saw it, and how far it went (Rahaman et al., 2026).

There is a subtler dimension to this worth naming. Most users do not configure their feeds. They encounter the algorithmic output as though it were simply “the internet” — a neutral reflection of what is being said. The naturalisation of the curation is part of the curation’s power. A user who perceives the feed as a curated, commercially motivated selection applies different scrutiny than one who perceives it as transparent. The invisibility of the selection, as Winner (1980) noted of Moses’s bridges, is what makes the politics so effective.

III. Epistemic Hierarchies and the Global South

The third register is epistemic. Gillespie (2014) argues that platforms do not merely distribute content — they constitute a public by deciding what counts as the kind of content that should reach one. That is an epistemic act. It determines not just what circulates but which claims count as credible, which forms of evidence are legible, whose speech is recognised as knowledge.

The Global South cuts across these hierarchies unevenly. Algorithmic credibility systems are built from institutional markers that reflect the media ecology of the North Atlantic: editorial correction policies, Wikipedia presence, citation in the English-language knowledge graph. An investigative outlet that lacks these markers — not because its journalism is weak but because it operates in a different language, a different institutional environment, with different infrastructure — may be systematically disadvantaged in algorithmic ranking regardless of its actual output. The standard is technical. The structural consequence is not neutral (Muzykant et al., 2022).

The consequences are acute where media literacy infrastructure is thin. Bangladesh had over 64 million social media user identities in October 2025, with

Facebook the dominant platform for news (Kemp, 2025). For a substantial portion of those users, the algorithmic feed is not one source among several — it is the primary interface with public information. Van Dijck (2013) describes the result as ‘platform sociality’: forms of epistemic life organised around platform affordances rather than pre-existing social norms. In contexts like Bangladesh, this is not a background condition. It is the foreground. The values encoded in the algorithm — what counts as credible, what counts as engaging, what gets distributed and what does not — were produced in institutional contexts that had no accountability relationship to Bangladeshi users, and they now shape the informational conditions of democratic life here. Winner’s insight that the politics are in the design has, in this context, consequences that extend well beyond anything he was analysing.

Conclusion

Winner’s question — do artefacts have politics? — was answerable in 1980 with a bridge. It is answerable now with an algorithm, and the answer is the same, at a scale and with a reach that Moses never approached. The politics are in the engagement optimisation, in the credibility definitions, in the naturalised curation that most users never perceive as curation at all. They are exercised through visibility decisions that no prior communication institution made at this volume, this speed, or this opacity.

What a critical communication theory of algorithmic systems needs, and largely does not yet have, is an account of governance — not just of design. Winner’s framework is about how political choices get inscribed at the point of creation. But algorithmic systems are not static artefacts. They are continuously governed: daily decisions about what to amplify, what to suppress, what to remove, what to leave alone. Those governance decisions are made at scale, without public accountability, and they shape what billions of people know and believe. That is a political problem. It is also, increasingly, a journalism problem.

Understanding the structural logic of these systems — not their proprietary specifications but their observable patterns of consequence — is a precondition for any serious account of how public knowledge is produced and governed now. That is not a call for a new subdiscipline. It is the minimum requirement for communication scholarship that wants to remain in contact with its subject matter.

References

- Bail, C. A., Argyle, L. P., Brown, T. W., Bumpus, J. P., Chen, H., Hunzaker, M. B. F., Lee, J., Mann, M., Merhout, F., & Volfovsky, A. (2018). Exposure to opposing views on social media can increase political polarization. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 115(37), 9216–9221. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1804840115>
- Gillespie, T. (2014). The relevance of algorithms. In T. Gillespie, P. J. Boczkowski, & K. A. Foot (Eds.), *Media technologies: Essays on communication, materiality, and society* (pp. 167–194). MIT Press.
- Haugen, F. (2021, October 5). Testimony of Frances Haugen before the United States Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation. U.S. Senate.
- Kemp, S. (2025, November). Digital 2026: Bangladesh. DataReportal. <https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-bangladesh>
- Muzykant, V. L., Hossain, B., Muqsith, M. A., & Fatima, M. J. (2022). Media literacy and fake news: Bangladesh perspective. *Jurnal Cita Hukum*, 10(2), 223–238. <https://doi.org/10.15408/jch.v10i2.25921>
- Rahaman, A., Efaz, A. R., Rajon, M. A., Ashraf, A., & Juearia, Z. (2026). Fight against disinformation and fact-checking in Bangladesh's July 2024 uprising: The digital battlefields. *Discover Global Society*, 4, 8. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s44282-026-00337-2>
- van Dijck, J. (2013). *The culture of connectivity: A critical history of social media*. Oxford University Press.
- Winner, L. (1980). Do artifacts have politics? *Daedalus*, 109(1), 121–136.